

It's A Rule

A two-minute customer story. Deadpan testimonial, filmed on a trading estate outside Norwich.

Accent. The whole cast is broad Norfolk, Precious included, but she talks like a policy document. Nobody in it is joking.

The principle. Precious runs the day shift at a warehouse. Her boss asked her once, in passing, for a team-building exercise. She had never written a line of code, so she asked Code Overlord, and its agents built her an app she called Everyone Joins In. It worked, so she kept asking it for more exercises, and more often, until a different one ran every ten minutes, everybody in the building loved each other, and nobody did any work.

Why it is funny. The engine is success. Every exercise works, so she adds another and runs it more often, and the app never runs the same one twice. What it costs is the one thing the building is for, and nobody minds.

ON SCREEN: FEBRUARY 2027.

Precious Adeyemi runs the day shift. Nine people, picking orders and sending them out. Gary runs the site. Gary is upstairs.

Gary came down once, said they should do a team-building thing sometime, and carried on to his car with a bag from Greggs.

She typed one sentence into Code Overlord, and by half three there was an app on the wall screen.

"Code Overlord asked me what to call it. I called it Everyone Joins In."

"Why that?"

"It's a rule."

The first exercise was Best Day: say your best day at work. John, nineteen, who had not said a word since Christmas, said his was the day Precious let him drive the lorry.

"If a thing works, you do it more. That's all I've done."

The app had one setting, HOW OFTEN, and it said WEEK.

"Is there an off?"

"Why would there be an off?"

So she had Code Overlord add more exercises, and turned WEEK to DAY. Jump for joy. Tell a joke. Picking went up eleven per cent.

In May, at the end of a three-legged race, Kev put his hand half up. He was still tied to John.

"They're brilliant, don't get me wrong. Could we not do them every other week? Only we're getting behind."

"Kev. You'd never have said that to me in February." A pause. "So what's the answer?"

Kev looked at the floor.

"More often."

She turned DAY to HOUR.

"Could anybody else change it?"

"No. It's my log-in."

By July Kev had told his joke nineteen times, so she had Code Overlord add a bit that thinks up a new exercise every time. She called it Brenda. Slow dance with a forklift driver. Forgive somebody. Brenda has never repeated herself.

"Brenda's not a person. They know that."

"Do they?"

"Kev's put her down as his next of kin."

In August she timed it. Four minutes of exercise, then fifty-six minutes of nothing.

"Nothing?"

"Picking."

That night she read out the options for HOW OFTEN, the way you read a form.

"Week. Day. Hour. Minute."

There was nothing under minute. She typed ten.

"Why not one?"

"One would have been silly."

Then she had Everyone Joins In ring people.

"Which people?"

"Everyone. It's in the name."

By September everybody in the building loves each other, nobody does any work, and nobody minds. Every ten minutes a klaxon goes and the big screen by the loading bay flicks to the next exercise, with EVERYONEJOINSIN.COM along the bottom. The lorries leave empty, and the drivers get hugged on the way out. A Tesco driver has been at bay three since half eight.

"He's not asked to leave." A pause. "He's opened up."

Gary comes down into the middle of a group cry.

"Precious. Tesco have cancelled us. Do you know what we do here? We [BLEEP] pick. We pick and we send."

Kev, gently:

"It sounds like you're carrying a lot, Gary."

Precious hands Gary her lanyard.

"I'll fall on my sword. I resign."

She picks up her bag. John steps forward.

"Precious."

The klaxon goes. The screen flicks over: TELL THE PERSON ON YOUR LEFT YOU LOVE THEM. John closes his mouth and turns to his left, which is the Tesco driver.

"I love you."

"I love you too, John."

Gary runs out after her into the car park and stops twenty feet away. She watches him.

"He'll want the log-in."

She puts her bag in the boot. Every phone on the estate rings: hers, Gary's, the tyre place, the queue outside Greggs.

"This is Everyone Joins In. Please hug the nearest person."

The nearest person is Gary. Over his shoulder, to camera:

"I typed one sentence into Code Overlord. Everyone Joins In has never done the same one twice." A pause. "You can't fault the software."

Card: CODE OVERLORD. Nothing after it.

What a Code Overlord user sees, and nobody else does. All of it is on her tablet and no feature is ever named out loud: the one sentence she typed in February; the box marked HOW OFTEN, going down the list; Brenda, the part she had added that writes a new exercise every ten minutes and has never written the same one twice; and the calls going out to everyone while she is asleep. Everyone else watches a warehouse fall in love with itself.

How this was made. Five rating rounds, two comedians' panels after he could not follow it, then rebuilt around his note (a different exercise every ten minutes, everyone loving each other, no work done), written long and cut to two minutes. The long version is beside it as `2026-09-19-film-every-ten-minutes-long.md`. Favourite beat: "One would have been silly."

Three things to decide. The title: *It's A Rule*, kept, because naming the film after the app would make the card read as an advert for Everyone Joins In instead of Code Overlord. The last shot: the car park and the Greggs queue, as written, or pull up over Norfolk with somebody hugging in every lay-by on the A47. Recommend the car park, because the Greggs queue is funnier than a county. The night shift and their caravan at Hemsby are in the long version and not this one. Recommend leaving them out, because the phones at the end already take it past the building.